

WOODS AND WATERS

Game and Fish, Dog and Gun Talk of an Amateur, Sporadic Sportsman.

By Harry Hampton

SOME EXTRAORDINARY SHOTS.

This is an inexhaustible subject, but one which always seems to meet a more or less willing ear—or eye. The only questions are where to begin and where to stop, what constitutes an extraordinary shot and what makes merely a commonplace? So only a few, which might be considered purely phenomenal, will be related.

The late William Elliott, whose book, *Carolina Sports*, tells of his adventures around the middle of the last century, makes a welcome statement. He says that a sportsman who relates sporting experiences is, of necessity, an egotist. The things which make the liveliest impression upon his senses are his own experiences. So we hope we shall be pardoned for an occasional personal reference.

One of the most unusual shots that has come under our observation was made by L. W. Boykin, Jr., whose real name is "Buck," on the Wateree swamp some 15 years ago.

A party was hunting turkeys and ducks, and a globbler was seen to fly across the river. Buck was using a three barrel gun with a 44 caliber rifle barrel under the two shotgun barrels. He looked after the turkey and saw him light about an eighth of a mile from the river bank. Hastily paddling to shore he climbed up the bank and saw the turkey sitting, with neck craned skyward, on the limb of a cottonwood. It was about sunset and the heavy gloom of the Wateree swamp gave practically the appearance of night. Buck hurriedly stuck the gun against the side of a tree, pointed the barrels a couple of feet over the turkey's head though panting from his race up the bank—and Buck is no syph! With the gun waving in circles, he pulled the trigger—on the dead run as it were—and the old turk did a high dive. The bullet had passed straight through his neck right under his head—to avoid spoiling the meat, Buck said!

The best piece of shotgun marksmanship that has come under our immediate notice was done by Bolivar Boykin at Smokehouse pond in Wateree swamp about the same time as the turkey episode—somewhere in that decade.

The hunt had come down the river with ducks and turkeys as objects of the chase, reaching Smokehouse about dusk the party had taken stands in the hope that a few ducks might come into roost. Bolivar was seated on the bank near the open end of the pond when 15 to 20 mallard swooped down to light. Seizing the opportunity offered by their bunching, he raised the 26-inch full choke Sauer—which belonged to his wife, incidentally—and knocked off three with the first barrel and two with the second! One was winged and made off into the willows and he had to "mallihack his ears a little bit," but the other four lay stone dead upon the water, and Jeff, the little red dog that used to cause so many laughs with his owner, old "Uncle Tut" Sanders, brought them to shore.

Many times this number of ducks have been killed on the water in two shots but I have not heard of its equal with ducks coming in on the wing.

When a small boy living in Charleston the writer used, upon occasion, to be taken by his father to hunt "marsh hens," called "sora rail" on the state hunting calendar. On one occasion what was thought to be a marsh hen was sighted, full 40 yards away sitting against a little point of marsh. Thinking it was a marsh hen—young boys take some time to learn what's what, it has later been learned with harrowing experience—I cut loose. When the thing was picked up it was found to be what the Charleston boys called a "scow-hatch-out-lax-night," but which later was identified as a least bittern. On going around the point of marsh a fat, warm marsh hen, slain by the same load, was found. This was a blind shot—and here's another.

While out dove hunting a year or two ago a dove was seen to light in a tall oak. Approaching and circling round the tree no trace of the bird could be found. The thought occurred, "I'll just shoot up there with one barrel and he might fly out and give me a shot with the second—Might hit him." Bang! Down came a mass of twigs, old leaves, acorns trash and one dove—struck through the wing!

Another luck shot occurred at Boykin at the close of a dove shoot. We were returning to the house and had stopped to get the mail at the mail box. For some reason I was carrying it under my left arm. Deas Boykin—one of the best dove shots hereabouts—had killed 24—the limit being 25, while I had failed to register. A dove flew over and Deas began pushing a shell into his gun, which he had unloaded, and he saw the limit in his bag. I raised my gun on the tips of the fingers of my left hand—still clinging to the mail—with the stock in my right elbow and shot—from the hip through the top of a little pine by the roadside—and down came the dove. I still remember vividly the look Deas gave me. It was not altogether friendly. Hadn't I wiped his eye and robbed him of his limit?

During my early career as a sporadic hunter, at about the age of 12 or 14 I was visiting at Willtown Bluff, then the home of the late Samuel G. FitzSimons. I was walking along a bank of a rice field in front of the house when I saw some sort of aquatic bird sitting in the canal (or trunk, to speak technically) alongside the bank. My cousin, Theodore FitzSimons, was farther out on the bank, and not knowing what kind of bird it was I looked quizzically at him. He made no sign and I walked on, looking at the bird, the bird looking at me. We met and passed, neither making a move. When I had gone about 15 or 20 yards beyond the fowl he decided to arise. At the same time I decided to shoot—and bagged him. It was a blue wing teal. The remarkable part of this story is why that teal sat there while I passed within eight feet of him, then decided to fly?

The most unusual shot of my experience was also made with teal. I was fooling around in a former rice field in a boat when two teal flew by, 15 to 20 yards away, one about ten feet BEHIND the other. I blazed away and BOTH TEAL FELL. The hindmost bird was somewhat farther away and the lead was correct for the distance of each from the gun. And there are some hunters who steadfastly swear they invariably shoot at the bill of a duck regardless of distance and speed! If they shoot thus and kill they shoot nothing outside the 15 yard zone!

This is probably enough of this for the time being. Presently some one will up and say what was once said to a notorious hunter and raconteur of South Carolina after he had been spinning yarns. "Tell us about that time you made that double on elephants with No. 9 chilled."